

A-LEVEL BUSINESS · END OF YEAR 12 · 2026 EDITION

The Step-Up Pack.

Year 12



Year 13

The jump to Year 13 is not a jump in content – it is a jump in **evaluation** and **synoptic thinking**. This pack shows your students exactly what changes, sets two summer tasks that produce something usable in September, and gives you a first-lesson diagnostic for the start of Year 13.

2

READY SUMMER TASKS

5

LEVEL-4 HABITS

1

FIRST-LESSON
DIAGNOSTIC

8

A4 PAGES

AQA 7132

EDEXCEL 9BS0

OCR H431

HOW TO USE THIS PACK

Now (end of Year 12): Pages 2-3 brief your students on what gets harder. Set Tasks 1 and 2 (pages 4-5) as summer work.

September (start of Year 13): Collect the summer deliverables, run the first-lesson diagnostic (page 7), and use the fortnight planner (page 8).

Hand the 5 habits (page 6) to every student – it is the difference between a stuck Level-3 student and a consistent Level-4 one.

THE HONEST BRIEFING

What actually gets harder in Year 13

Students who struggle in Year 13 are rarely short of knowledge. They are short of the three skills below. Name them early, and the year is far less of a shock.

Year 12 rewarded...

- Knowing the content and defining terms
- Short application – one point, one firm
- Single-topic questions in isolation
- Answers up to ~12 marks
- One side of an argument, briefly
- Calculations with the method given

Year 13 demands...

- ↑ Using content as a tool, not the answer
- ↑ Developed chains – point → effect → impact
- ↑ Synoptic links across two or more themes
- ↑ Answers up to 20-25 marks, sustained
- ↑ Both sides, then a justified judgement
- ↑ Choosing the right calculation, then judging it

THE THREE STEP-UPS, NAMED

STEP-UP 1 - EVALUATION BECOMES THE MAIN EVENT

In Year 13, the highest-tariff questions are won on **AO4 judgement**, not AO1 recall. "It depends on..." stops being optional. A technically correct answer with no judgement now ceilings two levels below where it would have scored in Year 12.

STEP-UP 2 - THINKING GOES SYNOPTIC

Year 13 questions cross themes deliberately: a marketing decision that changes costs and capacity; a finance choice that affects motivation. The students who connect **finance + operations + marketing** in one argument reach the top band. Those who keep topics in sealed boxes do not.

STEP-UP 3 - THE TEXTS GET LONGER, THE TIME GETS TIGHTER

Extended case studies, synoptic material and the biggest essays (20-25 marks, depending on your board) reward students who can read a long context, extract the relevant data, and apply it under time pressure – roughly **one minute per mark**, with the conclusion always written.

THE ONE SENTENCE TO TELL YOUR YEAR 12S

"Year 13 is not about knowing more. It's about judging better."

Set this expectation before the summer and the September step-up lands as a skill to build, not a wall to hit. The rest of this pack is how you build it.

WHERE THE MARKS MOVE

The marks shift – and the Level 3 → Level 4 ladder

The tariff climbs and the mark weighting moves up the assessment objectives. Show students the ladder so they can see exactly what a top answer adds.

THE TARIFF CLIMBS

12 → 20-25

The headline extended-response question roughly doubles in tariff – up to 20 marks on Edexcel and OCR, and 25 on AQA. A top-tariff essay is not "a bigger 12-marker" – it needs two developed arguments, integrated analysis, and a sustained, fully justified judgement.

THE WEIGHTING MOVES UP

A01 ↓ · A03 + A04 ↑

Across the A-Level, the marks for analysis (AO3) and evaluation (AO4) outweigh knowledge (AO1). The student who only revises content is revising the smallest slice of the marks.

THE LADDER – WHAT EACH LEVEL ADDS

L4

top

Integrated analysis + sustained judgement

Links themes together, then judges – "on balance... because... though it depends on...". Names the deciding factor.

L3

Developed analysis, a justified conclusion

Full chains of reasoning applied to the firm, and a conclusion that is justified – but topics stay largely separate.

L2

Some application, limited analysis

Points are made and partly applied, but chains stop early and judgement is thin or absent.

L1

Generic knowledge, no application

Correct content, but written about business in general – not about this firm, in this context.

THE GAP THAT MATTERS MOST

L3 → L4 is the Year 13 battleground

Most Year 13 students arrive able to reach Level 3. The marks – and the grades – live in the move to Level 4: **integration** (joining themes) and **sustained judgement** (a conclusion that weighs, decides, and says what it depends on). Every task in this pack is built to drill that one move.

SET THIS BEFORE THE SUMMER

Summer Task 1 – Analyse a real UK business

A single structured task that keeps business thinking alive over summer and produces a one-page analysis each student brings to the first lesson of Year 13.

Pick one UK business. Build the analysis.

~3 hours

Choose a UK business that has made a significant decision in 2025-26 – examples: **Greggs** (expansion), **Boohoo** (restructuring), **JLR** (EV investment), **Currys**, **Wetherspoons**, **Ocado**, or a local business you know. Then work through:

- 1 The decision.** In two sentences, what did they decide to do, and why?
- 2 The numbers.** Find two real figures (revenue, profit, cost, market share, employee count). Cite the source.
- 3 One framework.** Apply one tool you met in Year 12 – Ansoff, the marketing mix, break-even logic, or a SWOT – to the decision.
- 4 The trade-off.** Name one benefit and one risk of the decision *for this specific firm*.
- 5 Your judgement.** Was it the right call? "On balance... because... though it depends on...". Three sentences.

SEPTEMBER DELIVERABLE

One side of A4: **the firm, the decision, two figures, one framework, the trade-off, and a judgement.**

Students bring it to lesson 1. You now have 20+ live UK cases in the room on day one – and a baseline read of every student's judgement.

WHY THIS TASK AND NOT "READ CHAPTER 1"**It rehearses the exact Year 13 move – in a low-stakes context**

Apply a tool, name a trade-off, reach a judgement: that is the L3 → L4 sequence. Practising it over summer on a firm they chose means September starts with the skill already switched on, not cold.

SET THIS ALONGSIDE TASK 1

Summer Task 2 – The business-awareness log

Synoptic thinking comes from noticing how business stories connect. This light, repeatable task builds that habit across the summer – ten minutes a week.

Track three UK business stories. Connect them.

10 min / week

Over the summer, follow **three** UK business stories as they develop – from BBC Business, the FT, This is Money, or a sector you care about. For each story, keep a short log:

- 1 **Headline + date.** One line, with where you read it.
- 2 **Which theme?** Tag it – marketing, finance, operations, people, or external influences.
- 3 **The connection.** One sentence linking it to *another* theme. "This pricing move also affects their costs because..."

LOG TEMPLATE – PRINT ONE PER STUDENT

Story 1: _____ Theme: _____ Connects to: _____

Story 2: _____ Theme: _____ Connects to: _____

Story 3: _____ Theme: _____ Connects to: _____

SEPTEMBER DELIVERABLE

A completed log of three connected stories. Use them as **warm-up discussion starters** in the first fortnight – and as proof to students that synoptic links are everywhere once you look.

THE POINT OF THE "CONNECTS TO" LINE

It trains the single habit that unlocks Level 4

Integration is a habit before it is a skill. A student who has spent the summer asking "what else does this affect?" walks into Year 13 already thinking across themes – which is exactly what the 25-marker rewards.

HAND THIS PAGE TO EVERY STUDENT

The five habits of a Level-4 student

Not revision advice – thinking advice. These are the habits that separate a student stuck at Level 3 from one who reaches Level 4 consistently. Print this page and pin it.

1 Read the business news – and tag it

Ten minutes a week. Every story is a free case study. **The exam rewards real, current context** – and you cannot revise that the night before.

2 Think in trade-offs, never absolutes

There is no "good" or "bad" decision in business – only "better, given...". **Train yourself to name the cost of every benefit.** That is AO3 analysis, ready-made.

3 Finish every judgement with "it depends on..."

The fastest route into Level 4. A judgement that names **what the answer depends on** – demand, cash, time, the market – is a judgement an examiner can reward.

4 Connect the themes on purpose

When you analyse one theme, ask "what else does this touch?" A finance decision that you link to operations and marketing is **the integrated thinking the top band needs.**

5 Show your working – and then judge the number

In Year 13 the calculation is only half the marks. **A figure with no interpretation scores like no figure at all.** Always answer "so what does this number mean for the firm?"

FOR THE TEACHER

These five habits are the whole year, on one page

Refer back to them all year. When a student is stuck at Level 3, the cause is almost always a missing habit – usually **#3 (judgement)** or **#4 (integration)**. Naming the specific habit is faster feedback than re-marking the answer.

RUN THIS IN WEEK 1 OF YEAR 13

The first-lesson diagnostic

Before you teach a single new topic, find out where each student actually is on the one skill that matters most – judgement. This 15-minute task tells you, and tells them.

"A successful UK coffee chain is deciding whether to raise its prices by 10% to protect profit margins as costs rise. Recommend whether it should. (12 marks)"

WHAT TO LOOK FOR – AND WHAT IT TELLS YOU

- ✓ **Do they apply to the firm**, or write generally about price rises? (L1 vs L2)
- ✓ **Do they develop a chain** – price → demand → revenue → profit – or stop at "sales might fall"? (L2 vs L3)
- ✓ **Do they balance both sides** before deciding, or argue only one? (L3 ceiling)
- ✓ **Do they reach a justified judgement** with an "it depends on..."? (the L3 → L4 marker)

HOW TO USE THE RESULT

☐ Most stop at one side → **front-load evaluation** in your first half-term.

☐ Most write generally → **drill application** to the firm and its data first.

☐ Chains stop early → teach the **point → because → which means → leading to** chain explicitly.

☐ Strong already → stretch with **synoptic, two-theme** questions sooner.

PAIR IT WITH THE SUMMER DELIVERABLES

You now have two data points on day one

The summer business analysis (Task 1) shows you how each student applies and judges in their own time; the diagnostic shows you how they do it cold, under exam conditions. Together they tell you exactly where to start – and which students need the habits on page 6 most.

YOUR SEPTEMBER PLAN

The first fortnight of Year 13

A simple sequence that turns the summer work into momentum, sets the standard early, and makes the step-up feel deliberate rather than abrupt.

THE FORTNIGHT, STEP BY STEP

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Lesson 1: collect Task 1 analyses; three students share their firm + judgement aloud. | ☐ Lesson -2: run the diagnostic; mark for judgement, not content. |
| ☐ Lesson 2: hand out the five habits; set them as the year's standard. | ☐ Lesson 3: use a Task 2 news story as a synoptic warm-up. |
| ☐ Week 2: first 16/20-marker; feedback names the missing habit, not just the mark. | ☐ Week 2: set the expectation – every answer ends with "it depends on...". |

HOW TO USE THIS PACK

Set it now. Bank the September head-start.

Print pages 4-6 for students before the summer. Keep pages 7-8 for your September planning. The whole point is that Year 13 starts with the step-up already in motion – your students arrive thinking in trade-offs, judgements and connections, and you spend September building, not back-filling.

Built for UK A-Level Business – AQA 7132, Edexcel 9BS0, OCR H431. Pairs with our free Sentence Stem Library, Model Answers and Examiner's Eye packs. Company examples are real and used for teaching; figures should be checked against current published accounts.

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